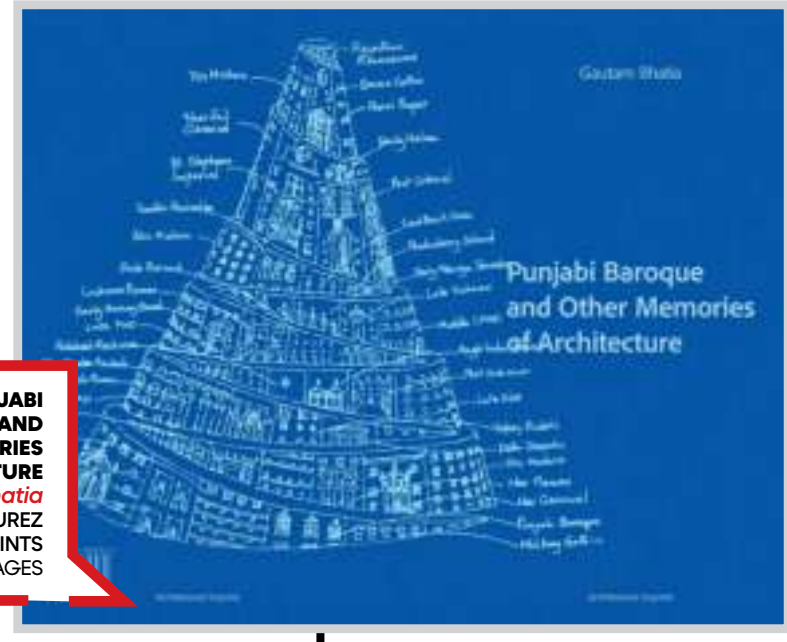
BOOKS ▼

BUILDING ON IRONY

AS ARCHITECT **GAUTAM BHATIA**'S *PUNJABI BAROQUE* RETURNS IN A NEW EDITION, HIS REFLECTIONS ON INDIA'S ARCHITECTURAL EXCESSES REMAIN AS RELEVANT AS EVER

In the 2023 movie *Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani*, the protagonist Rocky Randhawa (Ranveer Singh) belongs to a wealthy Delhi family that for some reason, lives in a replica of the White House. But if you think that was an unrealistic flourish on the writers' part, think again. Nearly three decades before the film, the architect, writer and artist Gautam Bhatia had described headstrong and tasteless clients exactly like the Randhawas in his 1994 book *Punjabi Baroque*. Bhatia wrote, "I have spent evenings discussing stylistic expediency, the fluent austerity of modernist forms, and other important clichés of the profession, only to be told by the client that the exterior of the house should be done in French Renaissance or Venetian Gothic, or any other style that would look good in downtown Lucknow." In a similar vein, the author was tasked with recreating Thomas Jefferson's home 'Monticello' in Delhi's Qutub Enclave—the kind of thing that can drive an architect up the wall.



PUNJABI BAROQUE AND OTHER MEMORIES OF ARCHITECTURE
By Gautam Bhatia
ARCHITEXTUREZ IMPRINTS
₹650; 275 PAGES

Punjabi Baroque, initially published by Penguin, is being reissued in November by Architexturez. It is a collection of essays recounting Bhatia's professional experiences, especially interactions like the one described above. And because architecture lies at the intersection of science, philosophy, public policy and a bunch of other disciplines, this gives Bhatia the opportunity to make many thought-provoking observations about post-independence India's blind spots. Talking about his writings during an interview, Bhatia says, "Architecture is a very public profession, in a way that's not true for, say, lawyers or dentists. Our successes are out there in the open for the public to see, and our failures even more so. And if you look at the largest Indian cities, it's clear that our failures—at the architecture level, at the urban planning level—far outnumber our triumphs. Forget aesthetics, even the utilitarian parts of our cities are subpar in most cases."



"IN THE LARGEST INDIAN CITIES," SAYS BHATIA, "OUR ARCHITECTURAL FAILURES FAR OUTNUMBER OUR TRIUMPHS... BOTH IN AESTHETICS AND UTILITY"

Complicating notions of utility and 'uselessness' were also central to Bhatia's recent exhibition of sculptures, *A Beautiful World*, held at Delhi's Bikaner House. The sculptures in question were soldered together in odd pairings—a cricket bat that morphs into a sniper rifle, a camera that melts into a locker, a sarod with a showerhead attached at the end, and so on. Bhatia says, "I wanted to take these objects beyond the realm of 'usefulness', and invite people to form new relationships with these objects... The inherently 'useless' nature of art has always interested me." ■

—Aditya Mani Jha